

Library of Celsus

The Library of Celsus at Ephesus was named after the city's former Roman governor, Gaius Julius Celsus Polemaeanus, whose tomb lies beneath its ground floor. Completed c.117 CE, it was a repository of over 12,000 manuscript scrolls, stored in niches around the walls on three galleried floors. Double walls behind the scroll niches protected them from the extremes of temperature and humidity, and there was also an auditorium for lectures or presentations.

Corinthian-style columns front the ground floor, whose three entrances are echoed by three windows in the upper storey. By making the columns at the sides of the façade shorter than those at the centre, the architects created the illusion of a larger building. Above the door stood a statue of Athena, goddess of wisdom, while statues flanking the front entrances represent wisdom (Sophia), knowledge (Episteme), intelligence (Ennoia) and valour (Arete): the virtues of Celsus. Reliefs are carved on the façade, while the interior was paved with decorated marble.

